

nation of the facts themselves will show that the influence of Zarathustra's followers remained confined within these limits. Only one exception must be made here, and that with respect to the Purîm-feast: it is very probable that it was borrowed from the Persians, but it cannot be demonstrated that its introduction satisfied a want which arose among the Jews themselves as a fruit of their own religious life. But other circumstances are involved here, as will appear in Chapter X, when we return to this subject. We will pass over the Purîm-feast for the present and confine ourselves to the remaining facts. To make our review of them as complete as possible, and not to disperse unnecessarily things which are closely connected, I will fix my attention not only upon the period of which we are now treating, but also upon the preceding and following centuries.

Perhaps even in Ezekiel, but certainly in Zechariah the son of Iddo, the contemporary of Zerubbabel and Joshua, we discover traces of the influence of the Persians, and this in *the doctrine of angels*. The belief in the existence and the activity of higher beings who are servants of Jahveh and carry out his will, is old-Israelitish.* In proportion as men conceived the distance between Jahveh and creation to be greater, or, to put it in another way, as the conception of Jahveh became more transcendent, the angels' office necessarily increased in scope and importance. Now the conception of Jahveh did indeed develop itself in that direction, from the beginning of the Babylonish exile.† We cannot wonder, therefore, that angels play so important a part even in Ezekiel and still more in Zechariah, and particularly appear as messengers between Jahveh and his envoy,‡ which does not occur at all in the older prophets. But at the same time it is probable that in this Zechariah at least imitated the Persians, with whom the heavenly

* Vol. I. p. 42. In the older historical narratives too, and above all in *Genesis*, angels occur repeatedly, and especially "the angel of Jahveh," who appears as his representative and speaks as though he were Jahveh himself.

† Comp. Vol. II. pp. 111, sq., 127-129. ‡ Comp. Vol. II. pp. 111, 211, sq.